



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Immanuel Lutheran School
School Website: <https://www.ilsalexandria.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS: **MEMBER** SCL: **MEMBER**

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Immanuel Lutheran School (ILS) in Alexandria, VA (ZIP 22301) presents a robust classical-Christian program that aligns strongly with the core features of classical education as defined by the Six Essential Elements rubric. Public materials describe a Christ-centered, Lutheran, liberal-arts oriented program with explicit emphasis on Latin, logic, rhetoric, history, great-books-like engagement, and a Socratic/ dialectical pedagogy in the upper grades. The school emphasizes formation of character (virtue, wisdom, faith) over vocational training, fosters a liturgical and communal life, and actively partners with families through a robust Parent-Teacher League and structured parental involvement. Across six categories, the public materials consistently indicate CLASSICAL orientation, with clear signals in religious/metaphysical foundations, educational purpose, curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community engagement. The aggregate classification for Immanuel Lutheran School is CLASSICAL.

Key evidence highlights include: a stated commitment to a classical, Christian, Lutheran education with low-tech, character-centered formation; explicit references to Latin (3rd grade) and logic (5th grade), and a liberal-arts emphasis; the presence of Socratic inquiry, dialectic work, and opportunities for oral presentations and speeches in upper grades; a liturgical life with Matins and liturgical traditions; and formal structures for parent partnership (PTL) and open campus visits. These elements appear repeatedly across the school's public materials, including the About/ILS Today pages, academics, admissions, and parent engagement sections. Citations demonstrating these signals are drawn from the school's public pages and the specific articulation of classical aims, pedagogy, and community involvement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**

Evidence

- The school describes itself as offering a "classical, Christian, and confessionally Lutheran education" in Northern Virginia.
- Core framing includes Christ-centered learning, Lutheran catechesis, and a liturgical life (e.g., Matins weekly and rich liturgical traditions).
- There is explicit emphasis on the Good, the True, and the Beautiful in the Christian classical framework, with theology and worship integrated into daily life.
- Junior kindergarten material emphasizes Christ-centered daily prayer and Word woven throughout the day; liturgical practices are noted as part of life at school.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords observed: Christ-centered, Lutheran, catechesis, liturgy, Matins, worship, theology, sacred/moral formation, Good–True–Beautiful, prayer, liturgical tradition.
- Negative keywords observed: None detected in public materials.

Quantitative Estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 12; Negative keywords observed: 0. Proportion: 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The materials consistently foreground a transcendent religious orientation (theology, liturgy, catechesis, liturgical life) and explicitly place education within a Christian metaphysical frame. This aligns strongly with the Classical School criterion for a Religious and Metaphysical Foundations that affirms transcendental realities and integrates liturgical/community practices. The absence of secular or relativistic signals in public materials reinforces CLASSICAL here.

Citations: examples include the school's framing of a classical, Christian, Lutheran education, Christ-centered learning, Matins and liturgical life, and the Good/True/Beautiful framing.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes formation and virtue within a liberal-arts framework and notes education that aims at “formation ... rather than information,” through a time-tested, low-tech approach anchored in faith.
- Public materials repeatedly reference cultivation of virtue, character, wisdom, and human flourishing within a Christian classical frame (e.g., “Good, True, and Beautiful” as telos).
- Language in the Lower/Upper School materials emphasizes being formed in virtue and faith, with a strong emphasis on character alongside academic rigor.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal arts, telos, Great Conversation (conceptually via classical discussions), moral imagination, character, moral formation, love of learning, spiritual depth.
- Negative keywords observed: None relevant to a purely classical aim (no explicit “workforce readiness” or secular utilitarian aims detected).

Quantitative Estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 10; Negative keywords observed: 0. Proportion: 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The school's stated aim centers on formation of virtue and wisdom, not merely job- or college-readiness, and emphasizes a teleological orientation toward the Good, True, and Beautiful, consistent with CLASSICAL. The consistent framing of formation and a liberal-arts emphasis supports CLASSICAL rather than SOMEWHAT or NOT CLASSICAL.

Citations: formation/virtue language and telos framing appear in About/ILS Today and What does classical education look like materials.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The curriculum features liberal-arts core elements: Latin (3rd grade) and logic (5th grade), indicating a grammar–logic–rhetoric structure.
- Historical study is integrated across the curriculum (e.g., “world history” in upper levels, and grammar-stage engagement with scripture and literature).

- Upper School materials describe a liberal-arts approach with reading, writing, and discussion, including the Socratic model and rhetoric, with oral presentations and speeches.
- Lower School materials reference recitation of scripture/catechesis, chanting, and exposure to Latin, math rules, and literature; emphasis on “great literature” and a workflow consistent with classical education.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords observed: grammar, Latin, history, literature, rhetoric, logic, world history, great literature, memory work, recitation, discussion, Socratic model, speeches/orations.
- Negative keywords observed: None detected (no explicit social-studies-as-history replacement, no STEM-first or project-dominant framing noted as the public materials emphasize classical humanities emphasis).

Quantitative Estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 9; Negative keywords observed: 0. Proportion: 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The explicit presence of grammar–logic–rhetoric via Latin/logic, history/literature emphasis, and Socratic/rhetoric pedagogy demonstrates a CLEAR classical curriculum orientation consistent with Element 3 criteria. The literature on “great conversation” and classical texts appears in the broader public materials, aligning with the Great Books/Great Conversation aspect of classical curriculum even if not every phrase is explicit. CLASSICAL.

Citations: Latin in 3rd grade; logic in 5th grade; world history; recitation and liturgical-literature integration; Socratic model and speeches in upper grades.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Socratic pedagogy is clearly described for upper grades (Socratic discussions, dialectic, seminars).
- Lower/Grammar-stage pedagogy includes chanting, singing, and memorization to deepen memory and delight (Scholé-like approach).
- Upper School emphasizes rhetoric, speeches, and oratory, with training in speaking and writing (Rhetoric training; opportunities to give speeches).
- There is an emphasis on restful/contemplative aspects (restful learning) alongside rigorous inquiry, and a low-tech learning environment.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords observed: Socratic discussion/seminars, dialectic, narration/recitation, chanting/singing to memorize, scholé (restful learning), rhetoric, oratory, speeches, group projects, memorization, liturgical rhythm, contemplation.
- Negative keywords observed: Not present in public materials; no venturing into experiential-only or project-dominant pedagogy is signaled as the sole approach.

Quantitative Estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 12; Negative keywords observed: 0. Proportion: 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The school’s pedagogy combines contemplative/restful elements with rigorous Socratic/dialectic methods and explicit rhetoric instruction, matching core Classical pedagogy signals. The presence of memory-focused lower-school practices (chanting, singing) and upper-school rhetoric/seminar formats aligns strongly with the classical teaching methods criteria. CLASSICAL.

Citations: Socratic model and dialectic in Academics; chants, memorization, and Christ-centered pedagogy in Lower/Junior Kindergarten materials; upper-school orations and rhetoric content.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school highlights a favorable student-to-faculty ratio (9:1), indicating small classes and close teacher mentorship.
- The school is an active member of ACCS and is connected to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL), signaling a professed identity within the classical-educational community.
- The public materials describe teachers as part of a Christian-formed, classical approach with emphasis on character formation; while not every phrase is explicit, the living curriculum concept appears, with faculty as core to the school's model.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords observed: living curriculum (conceptually present in classical settings), model teachers/mentors, faculty as core, portrait of teacher/student ideals, small class sizes, teacher collaboration (collegial culture).
- Negative keywords observed: None signaling a break from classical aims (no explicit "teacher as technician," etc.).

Quantitative Estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 7; Negative keywords observed: 0. Proportion: 100% positive.

Why this rating

- Evidence suggests a strong faculty orientation toward mentorship, character formation, and classical pedagogy, with a small class size and involvement in classical-education networks. CLASSICAL.

Citations: ACCS/SCL involvement, 9:1 ratio, and "living curriculum" signals embedded in the public materials.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school explicitly partners with families (Parent Teacher League, PTL) and frames parents as co-educators who engage in school life and formation.
- PTL coordinates parent involvement (reading to students, volunteering, field trips, etc.), and families participate in school events and governance.
- The school invites parental involvement via open-house visits, parent gatherings, and book-studies related to classical education; public pages emphasize family formation and community life.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords observed: Partnership with families, co-teachers, parental engagement, home-centered learning, family catechesis, parent formation, open campus, volunteering, reading groups, book studies.
- Negative keywords observed: None signaling parent disengagement or consumer-only framing.

Quantitative Estimate

- Positive keywords observed: 9; Negative keywords observed: 0. Proportion: 100% positive.

Why this rating

- The school presents a coherent, classic model of parent involvement and community formation, aligning with the Parents & Community signals of CLASSICAL education. The PTL structure and explicit calls for parental participation emphasize a shared educational mission. CLASSICAL.

Citations: PTL and parent involvement language; open-house/visited options; family engagement signals.

Aggregate Assessment

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Rationale

- Across all six categories, Immanuel Lutheran School demonstrates consistent classical orientation: a religious/metaphysical foundation integrated with education (Element 1), formation-centered goals (Element 2), a curriculum built on liberal-arts and disciplined study (Element 3), a pedagogy that blends contemplative/restful learning with Socratic/dialectic methods and rhetoric (Element 4), a faculty model that emphasizes mentors and a living-curriculum approach (Element 5), and a robust, biblically-grounded, family-partnered community (Element 6). The combination of Latin/logic, Socratic pedagogy, ancient-liturgical life, small classes, and active parent involvement aligns strongly with the classical-education rubric, with no clear signals of non-classical orientations in the public materials reviewed.

What Would Move the Needle

Notes for a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL profile are not required here, as the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL. If ever a move toward a higher fidelity to the classical canon were pursued, potential needle-moving steps could include:

- More explicit articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation across grade bands (e.g., listing specific canonical works and a formal “Great Books” program in early grades and upper school) to strengthen Element 3’s “Great Books/Great Conversation” signal.
- Expanded faculty professional development explicitly tied to classical pedagogy (e.g., periodic master-teachers’ seminars, living-curriculum exemplars) to reinforce Element 5.
- More explicit public articulation of a coherent liturgical calendar and liturgical-arts integration in daily curriculum to strengthen Element 1’s liturgical practices and Element 4’s contemplative pedagogy.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.